Validation Source Independence & Conflict Module (VSICM)

Architecture Ecosystem: Structured Reality Standards™
Architecture Family: VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture
Parent Standard: Validation Source Reliability Standard (VSRS)
Operational Layer: Validation Source Reliability Governance Layer
Category: AI & Interpretation
Subcategory: Validation Governance
Type: Parent Standard Module
Governed Space: Validation Source Independence & Conflict
Version: 1.0
Status: Canonical · Open Module
Effective Date: 9 August 2026
Compatibility: OOF® Methodology OS™ · GOA™ · OBIDENITY® · INTEGROS® · ORA™ · AGA™ · AIG® · CLIA® · MGIA™ · ASGA™ · RIS™
AI-Readable: Yes
Authority: OOF®
Protection: MIP® — Methodological Intellectual Property
Canonical Language: English (UCL™)

Governed Space

Validation Source Independence & Conflict

Canonical Definition

Validation Source Independence & Conflict Module (VSICM) defines the governance framework for determining whether Validation Sources possess sufficient organizational, financial, methodological, informational, operational, analytical, and decision independence for their assigned evidentiary roles and for identifying, assessing, documenting, and governing material conflicts of interest, incentives, dependencies, shared origins, and influence conditions capable of affecting source reliability.

It establishes the conditions under which source independence can be distinguished from apparent separation and source conflict can be treated as a governed reliability condition rather than an assumed source failure.

Operational Role

VSICM serves as the fourth internal governance space of the Validation Source Reliability Standard.

The preceding modules establish:

VSIAM — Who or what is the source, and can evidence be attributed to it?

VSPLM — Where did the evidence originate and upon which upstream sources does it depend?

VSCCM — Is the source capable and sufficiently competent for its assigned role?

VSICM asks:

Is the source sufficiently independent for the role it performs, and what conflicts, incentives, dependencies, or influence conditions may affect that role?

The governed progression is: **Qualified Source → Independence Requirements → Independence Assessment → Conflict Identification → Incentive Assessment → Dependency Analysis → Influence Assessment → Independence & Conflict Determination**

VSICM does not determine final Source Reliability.

It establishes the independence and conflict conditions required for that later determination.

Module Operational Space

VSICM governs:

- source independence,
- organizational independence,
- financial independence,
- methodological independence,
- informational independence,
- operational independence,
- analytical independence,
- decision independence,
- evaluator independence,
- source dependence,
- upstream dependence,
- shared-source dependence,
- common-method dependence,
- common-data dependence,
- conflicts of interest,
- financial conflicts,
- organizational conflicts,
- contractual conflicts,
- reputational conflicts,
- personal conflicts,
- competitive conflicts,
- source incentives,
- influence conditions,
- coercion risk,
- selection bias conditions,

- corroboration independence,
- false corroboration,
- independence limitations,
- conditional independence,
- independence uncertainty,
- conflict mitigation,
- independence change,
- conflict change,
- and independence-and-conflict traceability.

Module Function

VSICM applies after source identity, provenance, capability, and competence have been sufficiently established.

Its function is to prevent:

- different source names being mistaken for genuine independence,
- organizational separation being mistaken for methodological independence,
- multiple publications from one upstream dataset being counted as independent corroboration,
- vendor-funded assessments being treated as conflict-free,
- internal evaluators being represented as independent where material incentives exist,
- common tools or models creating hidden analytical dependence,
- conflicts being ignored because the source is competent,
- conflicts automatically disqualifying otherwise usable evidence,
- incentives remaining invisible,
- and apparently diverse evidence bases deriving confidence from the same underlying source structure.

Independence Is Multidimensional

VALIDOS® establishes:

Independence is not a single binary property.

A source may be independent in one dimension and dependent in another.

For example:

Two organizations may be legally separate but use:

- the same dataset,
- the same model,
- the same methodology,
- the same consultant,
- or the same upstream evidence.

Likewise, one internal team may possess strong methodological independence despite belonging to the same organization.

VSICM therefore evaluates independence dimension by dimension.

Organizational Independence

Organizational independence concerns whether the source is structurally separate from entities whose interests may materially affect the evidentiary role.

Relevant relationships may include:

- parent-subsidiary structures,
- internal reporting lines,
- shared governance,
- common ownership,
- contractor relationships,
- or operational control.

Organizational separation may support independence.

It does not establish complete independence by itself.

Financial Independence

Financial independence concerns whether funding, compensation, ownership, commercial exposure, performance incentives, or other financial relationships could materially affect source behavior.

Examples include:

- vendor-funded testing,
- success-linked compensation,
- investment exposure,
- commercial dependence,
- contractual incentives,
- or financial benefit from a preferred validation outcome.

Financial interest does not automatically establish unreliability.

It creates a conflict condition requiring governance.

Methodological Independence

Methodological independence concerns whether two or more sources use sufficiently distinct methodological foundations.

Sources may appear independent while producing the same result because they rely upon:

- the same validation framework,
- the same benchmark,

- the same assumptions,
- the same test design,
- or the same analytical pipeline.

VSICM distinguishes source separation from
methodological independence.

Informational Independence

Informational independence concerns whether sources form conclusions from independently obtained information.

Two evaluators may operate separately but both rely upon the same evidence package.

Their judgments may be independently reasoned while their informational basis remains shared.

VSICM therefore allows independence to be decomposed into:

Independent Analysis

and:

Independent Information Origin

Operational Independence

Operational independence concerns whether the source can perform its evidentiary role without material control or interference by the Validation Object owner, operator, vendor, or another interested party.

Relevant conditions may include:

- access restrictions,
- controlled test environments,
- selective data provision,
- observer limitations,
- restricted system access,
- or managed interaction.

Operational dependence may affect what the source can legitimately observe or report.

Analytical Independence

Analytical independence concerns whether the analytical process is sufficiently separated from other analytical sources.

For example:

Several reports may be produced by different teams but all rely upon the same AI analysis engine.

Their conclusions may therefore contain hidden analytical dependence.

VSICM makes such shared analytical infrastructure visible.

Decision Independence

Decision independence concerns whether the source can reach and communicate an evidentiary conclusion without material influence from parties with a preferred outcome.

This may involve:

- reporting freedom,
- approval chains,
- publication control,
- contractual restrictions,
- management pressure,
- or another governance condition.

Decision independence may be particularly important where the source is expected to provide independent assurance.

Evaluator Independence

Where individuals or teams perform validation-related assessment, evaluator independence may require separation from:

- system development,
- operational ownership,
- financial responsibility,
- deployment authority,
- or prior design decisions.

VSICM does not require external evaluation for every validation.

It governs when independence is necessary and whether the required form of independence exists.

Source Dependence

Dependence may arise through:

- ownership,
- funding,
- data,

- methodology,
- infrastructure,
- information,
- tools,
- upstream sources,
- or decision authority.

Dependence is not automatically negative.

Many legitimate sources depend on other systems.

The relevant governance question is whether the dependence materially affects the reliability role assigned to the source.

Shared Upstream Dependence

VSPLM identifies lineage relationships.

VSICM evaluates what those relationships mean for independence.

Where several sources depend upon the same upstream origin, their apparent corroborative strength may be reduced.

Therefore: **Separate Sources + Shared Origin ≠ Independent Corroboration**

Common-Data Dependence

Multiple sources may independently analyze the same dataset.

Their analyses may provide methodological diversity.

They do not provide fully independent evidence origin.

VSICM preserves both facts:

Independent Analysis

but:

Shared Data Dependency

This avoids both overclaiming and underclaiming independence.

Common-Method Dependence

Multiple sources may process different evidence using the same methodology.

This may create common methodological bias or blind spots.

Common methodology does not eliminate the value of multiple sources.

But their independence must be represented accurately.

Conflict of Interest

A **Conflict of Interest** exists where a source possesses an interest capable of materially influencing or appearing to influence the evidentiary role.

Possible conflicts include:

Financial Conflict

Financial benefit or loss may depend upon the validation outcome.

Organizational Conflict

The source belongs to or reports to an entity materially affected by the result.

Contractual Conflict

Contractual obligations may constrain findings, disclosure, access, or reporting.

Reputational Conflict

The source's reputation may depend upon defending prior claims, systems, or decisions.

Personal Conflict

Personal relationships or personal benefit may create material influence.

Competitive Conflict The source may benefit from the success or failure of a competitor.

Decision Conflict

The same party may generate evidence and authorize the decision relying upon it.

Not every conflict requires exclusion.

Every material conflict requires visibility and governance.

Conflict Materiality

Conflict significance depends upon:

- the source role,
- the evidence criticality,
- Validation Depth,
- intended reliance,

- consequence of error,
- available corroboration,
- transparency,
- and effectiveness of controls.

A minor conflict in a supporting role may be manageable.

A severe conflict in a sole critical source may materially weaken Source Reliability.

Source Incentives

Incentives may exist even without formal conflicts.

A source may be rewarded for:

- faster validation,
- favorable outcomes,
- lower reported risk,
- successful deployment,
- higher performance metrics,
- reduced incident reporting,
- or another preferred result.

VSICM treats incentives as relevant where they may materially affect source behavior.

Negative Incentives

Sources may also face pressure to avoid:

- reporting failures,
- challenging leadership,
- delaying deployment,
- contradicting prior decisions,
- exposing organizational weaknesses,
- or creating regulatory consequences.

These pressures may affect source reliability even in the absence of direct financial conflict.

Influence Conditions

Source output may be affected through:

- managerial pressure,
- contractual restrictions,
- selective information access,

- editorial control,
- system-owner influence,
- tool-provider constraints,
- political pressure,
- or another material influence pathway.

VSICM identifies such conditions where relevant to validation reliability.

Coercion Risk

In high-consequence environments, a source may be unable to act independently because of explicit or implicit coercion.

Coercion risk may require:

- protected reporting channels,
- independent escalation,
- external review,
- source anonymization,
- or another governance mechanism.

VSICM does not prescribe one universal mitigation.

It requires the condition to be governable where material.

Selection Bias in Source Choice

Source reliability can be distorted before evidence is even assessed if validators selectively choose sources likely to produce a preferred result.

VSICM therefore allows governance of **Source Selection Bias.**

Relevant questions may include:

- Why was this source selected?
- Were materially credible alternatives excluded?
- Were only favorable experts consulted?
- Were dissenting sources omitted?
- Was the source set constructed to maximize agreement?

This protects validation from engineered source consensus.

Corroboration Independence

Source corroboration has value only when the degree of independence is understood.

VSICM distinguishes:

Independent Corroboration

Partially Independent Corroboration

Dependent Corroboration

and:

Apparent Corroboration

where appropriate.

False Corroboration

False corroboration occurs when several apparently separate sources produce compatible outputs because of hidden shared dependency.

Examples include:

- multiple articles citing one report,
- multiple AI systems using the same dataset,
- multiple consultants using the same analytical package,
- multiple laboratories relying upon the same flawed reference material,
- or several departments relying upon one internal source.

VSICM prevents repetition from being represented as independent validation strength.

Independence Requirement

Not every source role requires the same independence level.

The required independence should be proportionate to:

- the Validation Purpose,
- source role,
- evidence criticality,
- Validation Depth,
- intended reliance,
- regulatory requirements,
- and consequence of error.

Supporting evidence may tolerate dependence that would be unacceptable for a sole critical assurance source.

Conditional Independence

A source may be sufficiently independent only under defined conditions.

For example:

- independent analysis but shared data,
- organizationally independent but vendor-funded,
- financially independent but methodologically dependent,
- or operationally independent only within a controlled environment.

VSICM preserves these dimensions rather than forcing a single global label.

Independence Status

Possible statuses may include:

Independence Established

The required independence conditions are sufficiently satisfied for the assigned role.

Independence Conditionally Established

Independence is sufficient only within explicit boundaries or conditions.

Independence Partially Established Some material independence dimensions are established while others remain dependent.

Independence Undetermined

Available information is insufficient to determine the required independence.

Independence Insufficient

The source does not possess sufficient independence for the assigned role.

These conditions remain inputs into final Source Reliability governance.

Conflict Status

A material source relationship may also receive a conflict status such as:

No Material Conflict Identified

No material conflict has been identified within the assessed conditions.

Conflict Identified — Controlled

A material conflict exists but sufficient controls appear to constrain its effect.

Conflict Identified — Residual

A material conflict remains after mitigation and must continue to affect reliability assessment.

Conflict Materiality Undetermined

Available information is insufficient to determine conflict significance.

Conflict Uncontrolled

A material conflict exists without sufficient governance controls.

These are source-condition states.

They do not determine final Source Reliability alone.

Conflict Mitigation

Where conflicts exist, possible governance responses may include:

- disclosure,
- independent review,
- additional corroboration,
- source-role restriction,
- separation of duties,
- alternative-source inclusion,
- external oversight,
- methodological replication,
- or another proportionate control.

Mitigation does not erase the historical conflict.

It changes how the conflict is governed.

Residual Conflict

Some conflict may remain after mitigation.

Residual conflict should remain attached to the source record and propagate into final Source Reliability Determination.

This prevents mitigation from being treated as proof that the conflict no longer exists.

Independence and Competence

VSICM maintains another strict distinction:

Independent Source ≠ Competent Source

and:

Competent Source ≠ Independent Source

A highly competent internal developer may provide valuable evidence but lack independence for a particular assurance role.

An independent reviewer may be insufficiently competent.

Source Reliability may require both conditions in different proportions.

Independence and Provenance

Independence cannot be fully assessed without provenance and lineage.

A source may appear independent until shared upstream origins are revealed.

The architectural dependency is therefore:

Identity → Provenance → Capability → Independence

This is why VSICM follows VSPLM and VSCCM.

Independence and Source Reliability

VSICM provides one critical component of Source Reliability.

But:

Independence ≠ Source Reliability

A source may be independent yet:

- incapable,
- incompetent,
- poorly attributed,
- provenance-deficient,
- or otherwise unreliable.

Likewise, a dependent source may remain usable under appropriate controls.

Final integration belongs to the next module.

Independence Change Governance

Source independence may change because of:

- acquisition,
- funding change,
- organizational restructuring,
- new contracts,
- tool changes,
- new upstream dependencies,
- new data-sharing arrangements,
- role change,
- or altered decision authority.

Material changes require reassessment.

Conflict Change Governance

Conflicts may:

- emerge,
- disappear,
- intensify,
- become controlled,
- or become newly discovered.

Conflict history must remain traceable.

A newly disclosed conflict may require reassessment of evidence previously produced by the source.

Minimum Implementation Framework

1. Establish Independence Requirements

Determine which independence dimensions are required for the source's assigned role.

2. Assess Independence Dimensions

Evaluate:

- organizational,
- financial,
- methodological,
- informational,
- operational,
- analytical,
- decision,
- and evaluator independence

where applicable.

3. Assess Source Dependencies

Identify:

- shared upstream sources,
- common datasets,
- common methods,
- common tools,
- common infrastructure,
- and other material dependencies.

4. Identify Conflicts of Interest

Determine whether material financial, organizational, contractual, reputational, personal, competitive, or decision conflicts exist.

5. Assess Incentives and Influence

Identify conditions capable of materially shaping source behavior or output.

6. Assess Corroboration Independence

Determine whether apparently corroborating sources are genuinely independent, partially independent, dependent, or only apparently corroborative.

7. Establish Governance Controls

Where material conflicts or dependencies exist, determine whether controls, restrictions, corroboration, or additional oversight are required.

8. Establish Independence & Conflict Status

Record the relevant independence and conflict conditions.

9. Preserve Lifecycle Traceability

Maintain:

- Validation Source reference,
- Source Role,
- required independence dimensions,
- independence assessment,
- shared dependency map,
- common-data dependencies,
- common-method dependencies,
- conflict records,
- incentive records,

- influence conditions,
- corroboration-independence assessment,
- mitigation controls,
- residual conflicts,
- limitations,
- uncertainty,
- status,
- changes,
- reassessment triggers,
- and sufficient lifecycle traceability.

Independence & Conflict Outputs

VSICM may produce:

- Source Independence Profile,
- Source Independence Assessment,
- Organizational Independence Record,
- Financial Independence Record,
- Methodological Independence Record,
- Informational Independence Record,
- Operational Independence Record,
- Analytical Independence Record,
- Decision Independence Record,
- Evaluator Independence Record,
- Source Dependency Map,
- Shared Origin Record,
- Common-Data Dependency Record,
- Common-Method Dependency Record,
- Conflict-of-Interest Register,
- Source Incentive Record,
- Source Influence Record,
- Corroboration Independence Assessment,
- False Corroboration Record,
- Conflict Mitigation Record,
- Residual Conflict Record,
- Independence Status,
- Conflict Status,
- Independence Change Record,
- Conflict Change Record,
- and Independence & Conflict Reassessment Trigger.

Use Case 1 — Vendor AI Validation

Scenario

An AI vendor provides internal benchmark results, an external consultant's report, and three industry articles supporting the system's performance.

Application

VSICM determines that:

- the internal benchmark lacks organizational independence,
- the consultant is organizationally separate but financially dependent on the vendor,
- and all three articles ultimately rely upon the vendor's original benchmark data.

Result

Five apparently separate sources do not become five independent confirmations.

The validation process receives a structured picture of actual independence, dependence, and conflict.

Use Case 2 — Medical Device Assessment

Scenario

A medical-device manufacturer funds testing by an external laboratory.

The laboratory is technically capable and professionally competent.

Application

VSICM distinguishes capability from financial independence.

The funding relationship is recorded as a material conflict condition and assessed together with contractual controls, reporting freedom, laboratory independence, and available external corroboration.

Result

The laboratory is not automatically rejected, but the validation process no longer treats the source as conflict-free.

Use Case 3 — Multi-Model AI Corroboration

Scenario

Three AI systems independently analyze the same evidentiary dataset and reach the same conclusion.

Application

VSICM determines that the models are analytically distinct but informationally dependent because all three rely upon the same dataset.

Two also share the same foundation model.

Result

The agreement may still provide useful analytical corroboration, but it is not represented as three fully independent evidentiary origins.

Architectural Position

Validation Source Independence & Conflict is the fourth internal governance space of the **Validation Source Reliability Standard (VSRS).**

The progression now becomes:

Source Identity & Attribution → Source Provenance & Lineage → Source Capability & Competence → Source Independence & Conflict

VSIAM establishes:

Who or what is the source?

VSPLM establishes:

Where did the evidence originate and upon what does it depend?

VSCCM establishes:

Can the source perform the assigned role?

VSICM establishes:

Can the source perform that role with sufficient independence, and what conflicts or influence conditions must remain visible?

The final VSRS module can then integrate all four dimensions into a formal **Source Reliability Determination.**

Foundational Principle

Agreement between sources is meaningful only when the relationships, dependencies, incentives, and independence behind that agreement are understood.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Source Independence & Conflict Module establishes the governance framework through which VALIDOS® distinguishes genuine source independence from apparent separation and governed conflict from assumed unreliability. By governing organizational, financial, methodological, informational, operational, analytical, decision,

and evaluator independence together with shared dependencies, conflicts of interest, incentives, influence conditions, corroboration independence, false corroboration, mitigation, residual conflict, change, and traceability, VSICM ensures that source agreement contributes validation confidence only to the extent that the independence and conflict structure behind that agreement legitimately supports it.

Parent Resources

→ VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer

→ VALIDOS® Architecture Map

→ VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index

Internal Module Flow

→ Previous module: Validation Source Capability & Competence Module (VSCCM)

→ Next module: Validation Source Reliability Determination Module (VSRDM)

Related Documents

→ Validation Source Reliability Standard

→ About Validation Source Reliability Standard

OOF® MIP® Protection Notice

OOF® · Protected under MIP® — Methodological Intellectual Property

Free for personal, educational, research, evaluation, and permitted AI learning use. Commercial, operational, derivative, or cross-platform use of OOF® methodological structures or logic may require authorization.

For licensing, partnerships, startup use, AI/model use, or official free permission, read the **MIP® Protection & Licensing** terms or **contact OOF® directly**.

Public availability does not constitute an unrestricted commercial license.

Active Protection & Compatibility Detection applies.

Canonical Source

https://originopenfoundation.org/